

ISYS90045

Professional IS Consulting

Seminar 8

Professional Advice and Consulting Comms: Meetings & Interviews

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& Christina Parkes & Piya Shedden

(Based on contributions by Dr Rod Dilnutt; Christina
Parkes; James Kotsias; Dr Piya Shedden;
Chris Waddell; et al)

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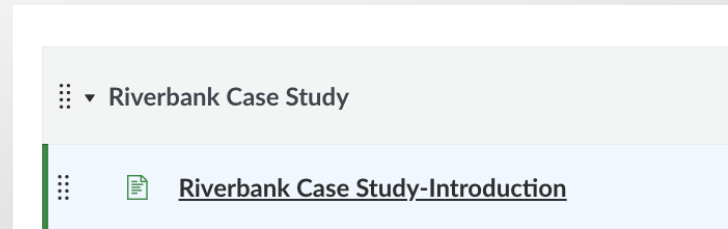
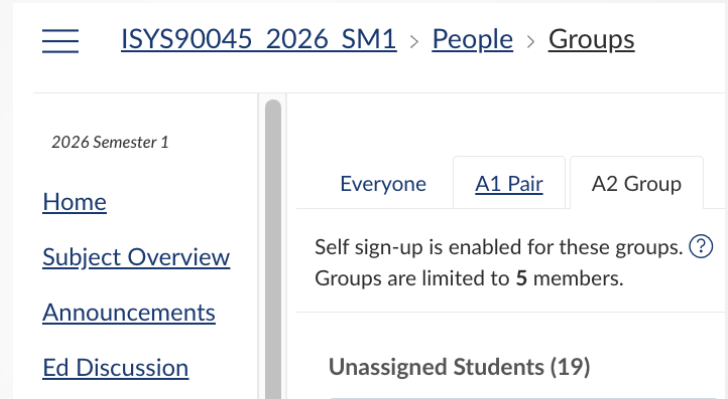
Housekeeping

AT2:

Students to please
join groups for
Assignment 2.

Tutorial Week 8:

Riverbank Case Study



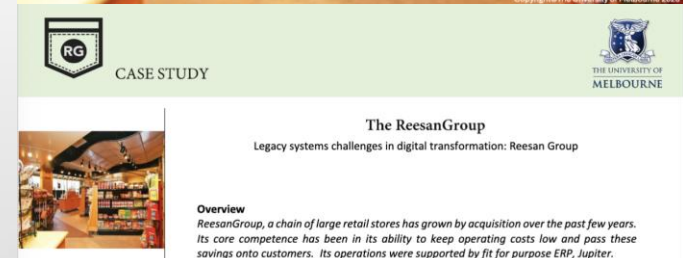
Kind reminder to continue engaging with the tutorial sessions and Reesan ☺



The Reesan Case Study

The [Reesan Case Study](#)  is presented as an easily recognisable scenario that we can consider in terms of consulting assignments. We will reference Reesan as we build our consulting skills.

Also, Rod has kindly prepared an [intro slide deck - The Reesan Group Overview](#) .



Content Timeline/Recap

Define and understand consulting and communication techniques:

- (Week 6 - Marc) Negotiation Skills
- (Week 7 - Rod) Report Writing; Workshops
- **(Week 8 - Marc) Meetings; Interviews**



Professional Advice & Consulting Comms

- ▶ Key information-gathering tools in the consultant's Toolbox
- ▶ What are they, when do we use them?

Category	Description
Meetings	• Small group-based discussion • Structured agenda – usually around 1-2 points • Low level of depth accomplished, moderate breadth • Two-way communication between parties • Conversation-driven • 0.5-2 hours in length.
Interviews	• Usually one-to-one • Structured agenda – around 1-2 points • Information flow is typically one-way (one asks questions, one answers) • Medium level of depth accomplished, low breadth • Conversation-driven • 1-2 hours in length.
Workshops	• Large groups • Structured agenda – programme of work • Information flow is many-to-many • High level of depth, high level of breadth • Activity-driven (using forms, pictures, collaboration tools) • Can be >2-3 hours in length.

Agenda: Meetings

Define and understand consulting communication techniques:
Meetings

- Define the role of meetings in consulting.
- Manage effective & productive meetings.
- Identify agenda-setting techniques.
- Identify meeting success factors.

Special thanks & credits
to Christina Parkes
for designing the initial
version of this seminar.

Meetings

Christina Parkes

▶ Exercise: Introduction to Meetings

What do we know about meetings?

▶ Exercise: your experiences, impressions,
in-person vs WFH virtual vs hybrid meetings...



Meeting participant stereotypes

Fast Company. (2016). "Every Meeting You've Ever Been To (In Two Minutes) | Fast Company". Youtube.

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-HZdU_VQvDI

[Coarse language warning]



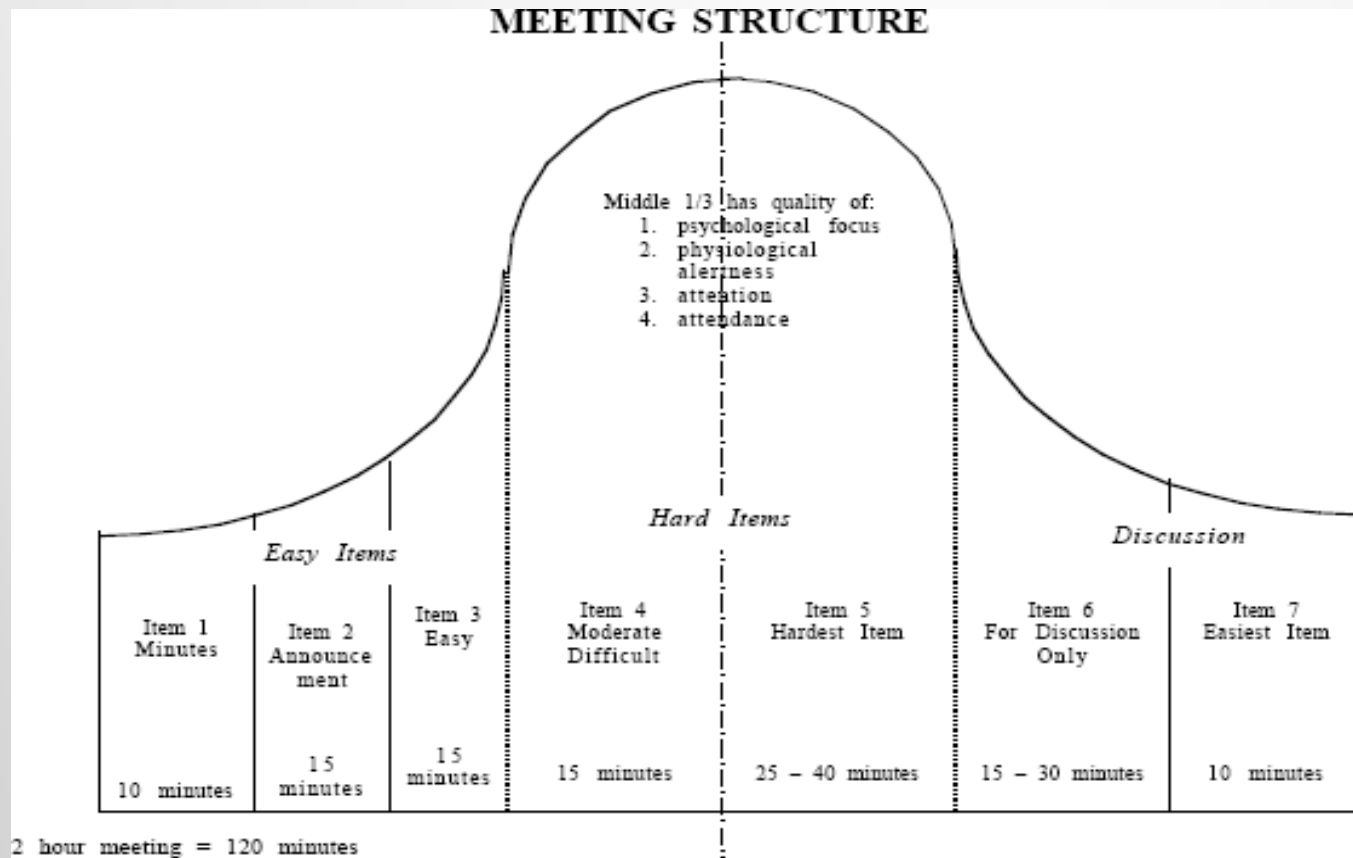
▶ Exercise: Self-evaluation

No	Question	Scale
1	I attend team meetings and I am on time	1 2 3 4 5
2	When I attend a meeting I feel positive about being there	1 2 3 4 5
3	I offer opinions and information (I speak my mind)	1 2 3 4 5
4	I encourage other participants to contribute their ideas	1 2 3 4 5
5	I speak to the issues rather than to people	1 2 3 4 5
6	I volunteer to help out or follow up on action items	1 2 3 4 5
7	I listen carefully to what is being said	1 2 3 4 5
8	I see meetings as a positive way to strengthen our team	1 2 3 4 5
9	I ask others questions to get them to expand on their ideas	1 2 3 4 5
10	I participate in meetings as a problem solver	1 2 3 4 5
Total	40 to 50 = A solid meeting contributor 30 to 39 = Contribute, you may want to get more involved 10 to 29 = Attitude toward meetings and work to be more of a meeting contributor	5= Always 4= Frequently, not all the time 3= some of the time 2= not very often 1= almost never

Managing Effective Meetings

How do we define a meeting?

Assembly of persons for a specific purpose



Exercise: When to NOT call a meeting?

WHY DO YOU WANT TO CALL A MEETING?



Meetings in Consulting?

General Discussion

- ▶ To define problems
- ▶ Unstructured problem solving (Week 10)
- ▶ Objective of gathering further information
- ▶ Crucial skill to be able to do this well
- ▶ Analysis
- ▶ Frameworks

Purpose of meeting

- ▶ Information gathering?
- ▶ Understanding?
- ▶ Evaluating?
- ▶ Designing?

Meetings in Consulting?

- ▶ Establish cultural expectations from participants from the beginning
 - ▶ Provide guidelines on promptness & tardiness
 - ▶ i.e., Gold coin donation for late comers
 - ▶ One person speaks at a time
 - ▶ No private conversations
- ▶ Encourage participation during the meeting not after... why?
 - ▶ ALSO: Considerations for online and hybrid meetings?

Challenges when conducting Meetings?

Reflect also on earlier discussions on Workshops.

Challenges you may encounter when conducting meetings

- ▶ Deliberately prolonging meetings to avoid work
- ▶ Participants who have their favourite subject or personal agenda
- ▶ Indications participants have lost interest
- ▶ Indications participants do not understand subject
- ▶ Indications participants may disagree though they do not express it
- ▶ Deliberately extinguishing creativity

Exercise: Group Discussion

Which of these challenges is the most difficult to manage? Why?

▶ Exercise: more failed meetings?!

Grady (2014). “David Grady: How to save the world (or at least yourself) from bad meetings”. TED Talks/Youtube.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=F6Qo8IDsVNg>

[We’ll only watch a snippet – but do watch the whole thing. Still relevant especially for flexi-work, remote meetings...].



▶ Exercise: What is the problem?

Recall: Grady (2014).

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=F6Qo8IDsVNg>



Research question / catchup

Mon 2024-03-18 11:00 - 12:00

No conflicts

Marc Cheong invited you [Didn't respond 1](#)

Messages

Meeting Details

invite.ics

2 KB

When

Monday Mar 18, 2024 - 11am – 12pm (Eastern Australia Time - Hobart)

Guests

Marc Cheong - organizer

View all guest info

Reply

Yes

No

Maybe

More options

Meeting Preparation I

Create an Agenda

- ▶ What is an agenda?
- ▶ It's a tool for participants to focus on accomplishment

Technique for developing an agenda using “OPQRST”

- ▶ Order & Objectives – of the process
- ▶ Process – Which technique used for information gathering?
- ▶ Question – What is the starting question?
- ▶ Recording – Which method is going to be used
- ▶ Supplies – Stationary or tools required to perform the meeting
- ▶ Timing – What is the estimated duration of the process & tasks?

Meeting Preparation II

Create a participant list

- ▶ Include key decision makers to action items

Establish roles

- ▶ Assign a support assisting with logistics, note taking, time checks and to act a witness
 - ▶ Remember to be fair and not discriminatory!

Assign a duration of the meeting

- ▶ 60 minutes is about the length of time people can concentrate with being too distracted
 - ▶ Common to have 30 min meetings too!

Commence on time and conclude on time



Conducting Meetings: Speaking

Facilitating a meeting involves 2 key tasks

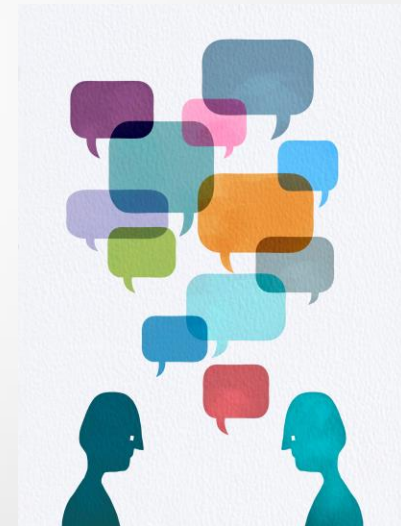
- ▶ Keeping the discussion on target
- ▶ Making sure everyone gets heard & participants' needs are met

Use data not people in discussions

- ▶ Language needs to refer to **facts** rather than opinion

Facilitating decision making

- ▶ Rather than begin with solutions, focus on a detailed analysis of where things can or do go wrong
- ▶ Seek consensus, avoid premature use of voting to arrive at decisions



Conducting Meetings: Listening

Listening

- ▶ Stay tuned to the mood of the participants
- ▶ Conclude meeting and thank attendees for their time
- ▶ After the meeting send out the minutes (no more than 48 hours)



▶ Exercise: Scenario Discussion I

Scenario: The Guru

You have a “really great” **app idea** – it involves enabling shareholder meetings for Company Annual General Meetings (AGM’s) to be run online rather than in conference centres.

However, you need Venture Capital (VC) funding in order get your idea into development.

There is one Venture Capital Guru that would be perfect to pitch your idea to, based in London.

**The problem is how do you get a meeting?
And what do you do if they agree to a meeting?**



▶ Exercise: Scenario Discussion I

Scenario: The Guru

- ▶ Part 1 – How do you secure a meeting with the “Guru”? You start to brainstorm with your friend how to ask for a meeting.
 - ▶ Brainstorm; “What is the best way to approach asking for the meeting”
 - ▶ i.e., Can you justify a meeting to the “Guru”?
- ▶ Part II -You have been successful in securing a Zoom meeting with the “Guru”!
 - ▶ What steps do you take to make sure the meeting runs well and it meets expectations?





● **A little rest – break for 10 minutes**

Agenda: Interviews

Define and understand consulting communication techniques:
Interviews

- Conduct effective & productive interviews.
- Understand effective interviewing techniques.
- Identify common issues in interviews.
- Practice effective interviewing techniques.

Special thanks & credits
to Christina Parkes
for designing the initial
version of this seminar.

Interviews

Christina Parkes

Interview Basics

- What is the purpose of the interview - exactly?
- Are there other ways of getting the information?
- Individual or group?
- What will your roles be? (who is taking notes?)
- Location/Setting?

Types of Interviews I

Purpose of interview is to conduct a conversation with a purpose.

The features of this conversation is that it has to be

- ▶ Planned
- ▶ Directed
- ▶ Controlled

What types of interviews are there?

- ▶ Face to Face
- ▶ Telephone
- ▶ Instant messenger (IM)
- ▶ E-mail

Interview Considerations

Importance of social cues in gathering information

Anonymity of interviewees

Cost of conducting interview

Geographies and time differences

Types of Interviews II

Face-to-Face

- ▶ Social cues are important information sources
- ▶ Sufficient budget and time for travelling

Telephone interviews

- ▶ Social cues are less or not important
- ▶ Some anonymity is requested

Video

- ▶ We are more comfortable with this format after COVID-19
- ▶ Advantage of sight and sound

Instant messenger interviews

- ▶ Parties are competent in typing & using computers

E-mail interviews

- ▶ Time zones, and synchronous interviewing means for one party interviewing at night

Conducting Interviews I

Individual or group?

- ▶ Panel? 1:1?

What will your roles be?

- ▶ Asking questions or taking notes

Question format?

- ▶ Open and closed and guiding questions
 - ▶ Yes or no vs broader answers – Examples
 - ▶ Reflect on lessons in Week 7/Workshops.
- ▶ Qualitative vs quantitative
 - ▶ Narrative vs Objective data

Conducting Interviews II

Active listening

- ▶ Play it back
- ▶ Let them know you've understood
- ▶ Get them to do the same!
- ▶ Remember and reflect on Week 7!

Notes and feedback

- ▶  **Exercise: Why is this important?**

HBR – Effective Interviewing

Job Interviews

Strategies of Effective Interviewing

We all think we know how to carry on our side of a two-way business conversation, but we can get much fuller and more-accurate information if we pay careful attention to strategies of effective interviewing. by Samuel G. Trull

Executive summary: 5 key research areas by Trull.

Preparation; procedures; questions; control; analysis/evaluation.

▶ **Exercise: Guess when this was published?**

Trull, S. (1964). *Strategies of Effective Interviewing*. Harvard Business Review. <https://hbr.org/1964/01/strategies-of-effective-interviewing>

HBR – Effective Interviewing

All quotes and paraphrasing attributed to Trull (1964).

(1) "The proper kind of preparation for the interview"

- Lack of prep - "greatest single fault" – per Trull's earlier research (1962).
- Do allow time for preparation
- Do not micro-manage, e.g., rigid approach

(2) "The value of such procedures as having an outline of points to be covered and taking notes"

- Written outline is required!

HBR – Effective Interviewing

All quotes and paraphrasing attributed to Trull (1964).

(3) "The use (and misuse) of questions and questioning techniques"

(4) "The kind and amount of control that the interviewer should exercise over the discussion"

- Rapport & Guidance
- Repeat summary to give "a mirror"
- Broad questions -> narrow down
- Don't rush!
- Listening skills

(5) "The analysis and evaluation of the information obtained"

- Be aware of both "objective" and "subjective" reference points

▶ Exercise: Consulting Interview Role Play (~15 mins)

(Credits for original scenario: Rod Dilnutt.
Case Study has been adapted based on current trends in hospitality...)

Scenario: The Hospitality Industry

"Our client owns a chain of pubs across Australia. Over the past year, the number of customers have fallen by 15%. They want to know why this is happening and what they should do to improve performance."

Your task: One plays the client, and one plays the consultant. Your goal is to ask clarifying questions, structure your approach, and give me a top-line recommendation **within a few minutes**.

Testing consulting essentials:

- Asking the right questions
- Structuring thinking
- Communicating clearly
- Giving actionable recommendations



▶ Exercise: Consulting Interview Debrief

Scenario: The Hospitality Industry

What to look for:

Do they ask clarifying questions? (e.g., target customer, competitors, market trends, pricing)

Do they set up a simple structure? (internal factors vs. external factors, revenue vs. costs, customer acquisition vs. retention)

Candidate Thinking (2 minutes)

Encourage them to think out loud:

Possible causes (e.g., competition from delivery/home meals services, pricing model, customer experience, health-conscious trends, cost of living).

Data they'd like to see (e.g., churn rates, competitor pricing, customer feedback).

High-level recommendations.

Wrap-Up (1 minute)

Ask them to summarise: **"If you had to give me your top two recommendations right now, what would they be?"**. Examples:

- Invest in alternatives: e.g., serve breakfast/coffee, non-alcoholic/healthy drinks...
- Improve retention by introducing loyalty programs or referral incentives.

(Credits for original scenario: Rod Dilnutt.

Case Study has been adapted based on current trends in hospitality...)

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Exercise: Consulting Interview Debrief

Stage	Strong Candidate	Weak Candidate
Clarifying questions	Targeted questions: customer segments, regions, offerings, competitor pricing	One vague question; how long it's been happening
Structure	Clear framework: Internal vs External; Acquisition vs Retention	No real structure, just talks about people not going anymore etc...
Exploring Causes	Identifies multiple plausible hypotheses: competition, churn rates, outdated ambience, cost of living, alternative food/beverage, healthy eating trends, people meet elsewhere	Mentions surface-level issues: price/cost...
Recommendations	Provides two actionable, strategic suggestions: improving retention + alternative offerings	Suggests generic tactics (lower prices, ads, discounts)
Overall impression	Logical, structured, demonstrates consulting mindset, communicates clearly	Unstructured, reactive, shallow analysis, tactical rather than strategic.

More details in a simulated interview on Canvas:
"Sample Interview Candidate Responses for the Hospitality scenario"

(Credits for original scenario: Rod Dilnutt.
 Case Study has been adapted based on current trends in hospitality...)
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Exercise: Scenario Discussion II

Scenario: The Guru Part 2

“...There is one Venture Capital Guru that would be perfect to pitch your idea to...”

The Guru is impressed!

You have been **successful** in securing VC funding for your start up – enabling shareholder meetings for AGMs remotely.

It has become too much work for one person; and with the funding, you can stretch it to cover a part time role to assist you.



You'll need to recruit. **How will you go about the interview process?**

(We'll cover “what will you be looking for from the candidates during the process?” in the next few slides...)

Interview Structure – Consulting Role I

(Credits to Rod Dilnutt for scenario)

Structure:

- Total ~50 minutes
- 40% case/problem-solving
- 30% market sizing/structured thinking
- 30% behavioural & fit

1. Introduction (5 minutes)

Briefly outline structure: intro → case/problem → behavioural → wrap-up.

Warm-up: “Can you walk me through your background and why consulting appeals to you?”

Interview Structure – Consulting Role II

2. Case/Problem-Solving (20 minutes)

Consulting interviews often test structured thinking with a case scenario. Example Case: “Our client is a mid-sized beverage company experiencing declining sales over the past two years. They’ve asked for advice on how to reverse the trend. How would you approach this problem?”

Follow-up prompts:

- “What factors would you investigate first?”
- “How would you structure your analysis?”
- “What kind of data would you need, and why?”
- “Based on your initial view, what are some possible recommendations?”

Look for:

logical structure, MECE (mutually exclusive and collectively exhaustive) thinking, clear communication, data-driven mindset...

Interview Structure – Consulting Role III

3. Market Sizing / Estimation (10 minutes)

Quick “guesstimate” style question: “How many cups of coffee are sold each day in Sydney?”

Candidate should break it into steps: population → % coffee drinkers → average cups/day → price assumptions.

4. Behavioural / Fit (10 minutes)

“Tell me about a time you had to influence a group without having direct authority.”

“Give an example of when you worked with a difficult stakeholder. How did you handle it?”

“Consulting often means tight deadlines. Can you share a time you managed competing priorities effectively?”

5. Wrap-Up (5 minutes)

Invite candidate questions; Provide feedback (if practice).



Canvas: Discussion Exercise

Discussion exercise: Please see Ed Discussion for the full scenario background.

Discussion - Consulting Interviews and Recap on Communication Techniques (Week 8) #26

Scenario 1. A Consultant's First Day

You sit in the lobby of a swanky new building in the Melbourne CBD. You're dressed in a crisp new work outfit, your hair is on point and your shoes are shiny (but hurt a little). You're surrounded by glass, steel, marble and leather. Hundreds of busy-looking people hurry through to the elevators hidden behind security gates.

You're a prospective graduate consultant for one of the largest global consultancies. **You successfully made it through almost all the gruelling assessment stages and you've now 'made it'... to the FINAL interview.**

You're waiting on your 'buddy' to come down and take you to the next huge step in your career that's waiting for you, up on the 25th floor.

What are the attitudes and behaviours you feel are important – and that you're going to bring into the interview - to prove that you have what it takes to be a team member? List three points.

Scenario 2. Getting Information

Suppose you ace the interview - well done! You slowly build your skillset and experience, until one day...

You have been assigned to an engagement concerning FreshMeals, a major fast-food chain in Melbourne.

FreshMeals is improving their Human Resource Management practices, in response to industry-wide concerns about staff underpayment.

Your senior colleague, a Business Analyst, asks you to start planning these tasks.

- find out from casual staff (e.g., students, youth) about their experiences with their fortnightly payments and possible underpayment?
- update FreshMeals' legal team on progress and blockers to the project, on a weekly basis, as required by the BA governance plan.?
- get input from FreshMeals branch managers on the features needed in an efficient HRM mobile app?

Lucky you have learnt from Rod and Marc about interviews, report writing, meetings, and workshops! For each task, reflect on the best way to accomplish them, given the 4 techniques learnt in Week 7-8.

Summary for Week 8

This seminar has explored methods of communicating as a consultant

- Meetings
- Interviews

In the past two weeks, you have explored four structured communication styles, understood their roles, success factors, how to troubleshoot issues, and have completed simulated tasks in a consulting setting.